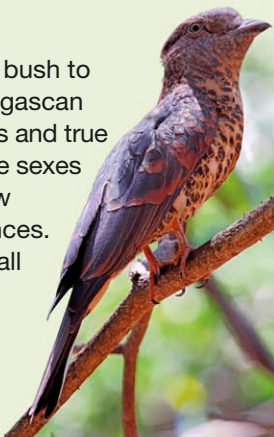


Cuckoo roller

PHYLUM	Chordata
CLASS	Aves
ORDER	Leptosomiformes
FAMILIES	1
SPECIES	1

Found from sea-level bush to high forests, this Madagascan bird is related to trogons and true rollers. Unlike rollers, the sexes differ. Three races show minor plumage differences. Like cuckoos, their small feet have two toes turned backward.

CUCKOO ROLLER
Females and juveniles are richly colored and heavily spotted beneath, for camouflage in their forest habitat.



Leptosomus discolor

Cuckoo roller



Location Madagascar



Cuckoo rollers eat insects and small reptiles. Like some cuckoos, they take hairy caterpillars that are distasteful to other birds; the stomach may be lined with

Length	40–50 cm (16–20 in)
Weight	160–300 g (6–11 oz)
Plumage	Sexes differ
Migration	Nonmigrant
Status	Least concern

caterpillar hairs. Their lifestyle is poorly known, but about four white eggs are laid in an unlined tree cavity and incubated by the female for about 20 days. Cuckoo rollers are tame and, so far, relatively unaffected by widespread deforestation.



Kingfishers and relatives

PHYLUM	Chordata
CLASS	Aves
ORDER	Coraciiformes
FAMILIES	6
SPECIES	160

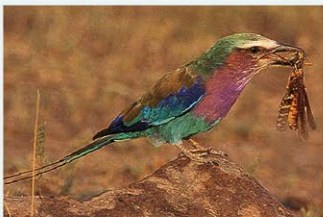
Famous for their spectacular dives into water, the kingfishers are arguably the most familiar birds in this group. However, there are 6 very different families in all (including bee-eaters, todies, motmots, and rollers), most of which are not waterside birds. They are found worldwide, mainly in woodland, and all nest in holes.

Anatomy

Most members of this group have a relatively large head and bill, and a compact body with a vividly colored plumage. Their legs are often short, and two of the front toes are partially fused together near the base. Most species have broad wings, but in the highly aerial bee-eaters, they are relatively long and pointed.



BILL SHAPES
Most members of this group have a strong bill, useful for dealing with animal prey. However, there is great variation in bill shape and size.



CATCHING INSECTS
Rollers, such as this lilac-breasted roller (left), drop from an elevated perch to catch their prey on the ground. A few also catch flying insects in mid-air.

Feeding

Kingfishers adopt a hunting strategy that is common to many birds in this group. The bird sits still, watching for movement, and then takes off in pursuit. A kingfisher often stuns its prey by beating it on a hard surface before swallowing it. Most members of this group are meat-eaters, feeding on all kinds of animals, including other birds, fish, mammals, and insects.



HUNTING FOR FISH
A kingfisher perches or hovers over water, watching below for signs of movement. When it sees a fish, it plunge-dives head-first and grabs—never spears—its prey.

Megasceryle alcyon

Belted kingfisher



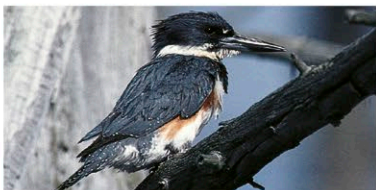
Location North America to N. South America, Caribbean

Length	11½ in (29 cm)
Weight	5 oz (150 g)
Plumage	Sexes differ
Migration	Partial migrant
Status	Least concern



This is one of the few species of kingfishers to be found in North America. The female has a prominent reddish brown band across the lower breast. It feeds mainly on fish but also eats

crustaceans, amphibians, and reptiles. During courtship, these birds circle high overhead and chase each other while uttering shrill cries. The male offers fish to the perching female as part of the courtship ritual. This kingfisher builds its nest in a chamber at the end of a burrow excavated in earth, usually in a river bank, but also in man-made earthworks. Birds in the north of the range migrate south when lakes and rivers freeze over.



Ceryle rudis

Pied kingfisher



Location Africa, W., S., and S.E. Asia

Length	10 in (25 cm)
Weight	3¼ oz (90 g)
Plumage	Sexes differ
Migration	Nonmigrant
Status	Least concern



Unlike most other kingfishers, this boldly marked kingfisher is equally at home over fresh and salt water, and sometimes ventures far out over estuaries and shallow coasts. It flies rapidly, but often

hovers over the water when locating prey, before diving down to make a catch. The pied kingfisher nests in sandy banks, with up to 4 young nonbreeding adults acting as helpers for a breeding pair. Assertive and vocal, it has a high-pitched call, which it often makes on the wing.

